

Spanish Wine Labels — A Complete Visual Guide

Rioja · Ribera del Duero · Priorat · Rías Baixas · Cava · Sherry · kazmicellars.com

Spain's label system has one powerful common thread: the aging tier. Joven → Crianza → Reserva → Gran Reserva appears across Rioja, Ribera del Duero, and most red DO wines. But Priorat skips the tiers entirely. Rías Baixas is one of the rare places where the grape appears. Sherry has its own universe.

THE SPANISH CLASSIFICATION & AGING SYSTEM

DOCa	Denominación de Origen Calificada — Spain's highest tier. Only two: Rioja and Priorat (DOQ in Catalan).
DO	Denominación de Origen — the standard quality designation. Over 70 DOs covering most quality Spanish wine.
Vino de Pago	Single estate designation — like Italy's single-estate DOC. Very rare. Estates with internationally recognised vineyards can apply.
Joven / Cosecha	Young wine with minimal or no oak aging. Fresh, fruit-forward. No minimum oak requirement.
Crianza (red)	Minimum 24 months total aging — at least 6 months in oak barrel. The entry point of the aging tier system.
Reserva (red)	Minimum 36 months total — at least 12 in oak. Made only in good vintages.
Gran Reserva (red)	Minimum 60 months total — at least 18 in oak. Only in exceptional vintages. Released ready to drink.
Crianza/Reserva/Gran Reserva timing varies by region	Rioja Gran Reserva: 2 years oak + 3 years bottle. Ribera del Duero differs. Always check region-specific rules.
Embotellado en la Propiedad	Estate-bottled — from the producer's own vineyards. The highest quality indicator.
Embotellado en la Bodega	Bottled at the winery — grapes may be bought from growers.

RIOJA & RIBERA DEL DUERO — THE AGING TIER SYSTEM IN ACTION

Both Rioja and Ribera del Duero use the aging tier system, but Rioja's is the most famous. Gran Reserva is the headline — the tier name appears large and tells you the wine has been aged for 5+ years.



Rioja DOCa Gran Reserva — Tempranillo dominant. Grape never shown. The aging tier is the key label element.

1	Bodega	'Bodega' = winery. CVNE is one of Rioja's historic houses, founded 1879.
2	Wine Name	Proprietary name — 'Imperial' is CVNE's flagship Gran Reserva. The wine name often carries more weight than the bodega name.
3	RIOJA	The appellation — Spain's most famous. Grape variety (Tempranillo dominant) is never stated. Rioja = Tempranillo.
4	GRAN RESERVA	The aging tier — Spain's highest. For red Rioja: minimum 2 years in oak + 3 years in bottle = 5 years total before release. Only made in exceptional vintages.
5	Vintage	By the time Gran Reserva reaches market, it's already 5+ years old and ready to drink.
6	DOCa	'Denominación de Origen Calificada' — Spain's highest classification. Only Rioja and Priorat hold DOCa status.
7	Bottling Note	'Embotellado en la Bodega' = bottled at the winery. 'Embotellado en la Propiedad' = estate-bottled from own vineyards.



Ribera del Duero DO — Tinto Fino (Tempranillo) dominant. No standard aging tier stated. Producer reputation leads.

1	Producer	Vega Sicilia — arguably Spain's most famous winery. The wine name 'Único' is the brand.
2	Wine Name	'Único' is Vega Sicilia's flagship. The brand is the label headline, not the appellation.
3	DO Ribera del Duero	The appellation. Primary grape: Tinto Fino (Tempranillo clone at altitude). Grape usually unstated. No aging tier stated — Único is released 8-12 years after harvest.
4	Vintage	Ribera del Duero vintages vary. 2011 is outstanding. Único is only released in exceptional years.
5	DO (not DOCa)	Ribera del Duero is a DO — below DOCa. Despite this, it produces some of Spain's finest and most expensive wines.
6	Grape Note	Unusual — Vega Sicilia states the blend. Most Ribera del Duero wines do not show varieties.
7	Estate-Bottled	'Embotellado en la Propiedad' = from the estate's own vineyards.

■ **Rioja key:** Tempranillo is the grape — never stated on the label. American oak gives Rioja its distinctive vanilla/coconut character. French oak (increasingly used) = more subtle. The tier (Gran Reserva / Reserva / Crianza) is the most important label element after the producer name.

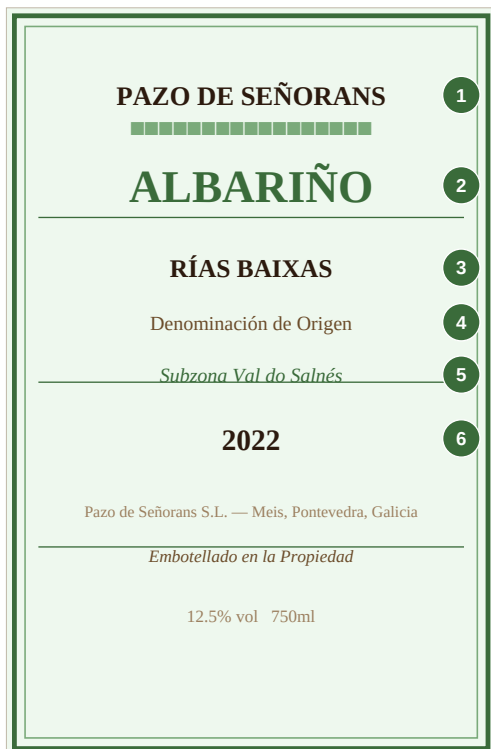
PRIORAT & RÍAS BAIXAS — NO TIERS & THE ONE DO THAT SHOWS THE GRAPE

Priorat uses no aging tier system — the producer name and wine name carry all the prestige. Rías Baixas is the notable exception in Spain where the grape (Albariño) leads the label.



Priorat DOCa — Garnacha + Cariñena on llicorella slate. No aging tier system. Producer name carries all the prestige.

1	Producer	Álvaro Palacios was instrumental in the 1990s revival of Priorat. The producer's name is the primary quality signal here.
2	Wine Name	'L'Ermita' — Palacios's most famous single-vineyard wine. One of Spain's rarest and most expensive bottles.
3	Vintage	
4	PRIORAT	The appellation. Ancient Garnacha and Cariñena vines on llicorella (slate) soils. No aging tier system — Priorat labels are minimal. Quality is implied by the producer name and price.
5	DOCa	Priorat is one of only two DOCa regions in Spain (Rioja is the other). Note the Catalan label uses 'DOQ' (Denominació d'Origen Qualificada).
6	Grape Note	Optional. Palacios includes the blend for transparency — most Priorat labels don't.
7	Estate-Bottled	



Rías Baixas DO — One of Spain's rare DOs where the grape (Albariño) leads the label. Grape and appellation are inseparable.

1	Producer	The pazo (Galician manor estate). Pazo de Señorans is one of the benchmark Albariño producers.
2	ALBARIÑO	The grape — and here it's the LARGEST text on the label. Rías Baixas is one of the rare Spanish DOs where the grape variety leads. Almost all Rías Baixas wine is Albariño.
3	RÍAS BAIXAS	The DO — Galicia, Atlantic coast NW Spain. Albariño is so dominant here that the grape IS the appellation's identity.
4	DO	Standard denomination — no DOCa status, but quality is consistently high.
5	Subzona	Rías Baixas has five subzones. Val do Salnés is the most prestigious, closest to the Atlantic.
6	Vintage	Albariño is meant to be drunk young — within 2-4 years for freshness. Some age well.

■ Priorat: Minimal label, maximal price. Old vine Garnacha and Cariñena on llicorella slate. No aging tier — read the producer, not the label tier. Rías Baixas: One of the few Spanish DOs where you see the grape (Albariño) front and centre. Almost 100% of Rías Baixas wine is Albariño — it's the appellation's entire identity.

CAVA & SHERRY — SPARKLING AND FORTIFIED: ENTIRELY DIFFERENT SYSTEMS

Cava uses a Champagne-style dosage and aging tier system. Sherry's label is built around the style type — Fino, Amontillado, Oloroso — which tells you everything.



Cava DO — Macabeo + Xarel·lo + Parellada, traditional method sparkling. Dosage and aging tiers similar to Champagne.

1	Producer	The bodega. Gramona makes some of Spain's most serious traditional-method sparkling wines.
2	Cuvée Name	Proprietary name for a specific prestige bottling.
3	CAVA	The denomination. Unlike Champagne (geographic), Cava is a method-based DO — it can come from several Spanish regions (mostly Penedès).
4	De Paraje Calificado	The highest Cava tier, introduced 2017. Single vineyard, minimum 36 months aging, manual riddling. Above Gran Reserva.
5	Gran Reserva	Minimum 30 months aging. The standard premium Cava tier. Quality Cavas are aged 30-120+ months.
6	Brut Nature	Zero dosage — no sugar added after disgorgement. The driest style. Same dosage scale as Champagne.
7	Vintage	Vintage Cava is a quality indicator — most entry-level Cava is non-vintage.
8	Grapes	Cava's traditional grapes: Macabeo, Xarel·lo, Parellada. Chardonnay and Pinot Noir also permitted. Better producers often state the blend.



Jerez DO — The Sherry TYPE is the centrepiece: Fino, Amontillado, Oloroso, PX. Everything else follows from that.

1	Producer	The bodega. Lustau is one of Jerez's finest producers, specializing in almacenista (small-batch) Sherries.
2	SHERRY TYPE	The TYPE is the centrepiece of every Sherry label: Fino, Manzanilla, Amontillado, Oloroso, Palo Cortado, Cream, or Pedro Ximénez. This tells you everything about sweetness and style.
3	Wine Name	Proprietary name for a specific solera. 'Los Arcos' is Lustau's benchmark Amontillado.
4	Solera Reserva	Indicates the wine comes from a multi-year solera system. 'Reserva' means it has spent extended time in the solera — often decades.
5	DO Jerez	The appellation — Jerez, Sanlúcar de Barrameda, and El Puerto de Santa María. The triple name (Jerez-Xérès-Sherry) reflects its Spanish, French, and English names.
6	Grape	Palomino is the Sherry grape. Usually stated on better Sherry labels. Pedro Ximénez (PX) is the sweet Sherry grape — always stated when used.
7	Alcohol	Sherry is fortified: Fino/Manzanilla 15-18%, Amontillado/Oloroso 17-22%. Always higher than table wine.

■ Sherry cheat sheet: Fino = pale, dry, saline. Manzanilla = like Fino but from Sanlúcar, saltier. Amontillado = amber, nutty, dry. Oloroso = dark, walnut, dry to off-dry. Palo Cortado = between Amontillado and Oloroso — rare and complex. Pedro Ximénez (PX) = very dark, very sweet, raisins. Cream = sweetened Oloroso.